

'We have all that Red Hat has, but our prices will pretty much be half'

Shane Owenby

Director, Linux & Open Source, Asia Pacific,
Oracle Corporation

In this interview, Shane Owenby, director, Linux & Open Source, Asia Pacific, Oracle Corporation, tells us there is nothing like 'one' open source community. He also presents what Oracle has, that he believes is missing in Red Hat, which makes the database giant a better alternative for customers. He shares with us Oracle's contributions to the Linux world, and expresses his surprise at how little credit the company gets for it.

Q What role does open source play in the overall Oracle game?

Well, we are clearly known as a private source company—the word 'proprietary' seems too harsh to us. I also think the term 'open source' is too big for us. We don't think that there is just 'one' open source community any more. Back in the days when it was very specific, all the open source communities were pretty similar. Now you've got very large corporations such as Oracle and IBM that have done some massive things in many different areas. Open source has diversified so much that we cannot refer to something as "the open source community" any more.

We evaluate open source projects based on our contribution to them or their usage. There can be some projects that we adopt; some that we will adopt and integrate; some that we will adopt, integrate and then contribute to; and there will be those for which we will take money and then provide support. So, each individual project has different

levels of commitment from our perspective, and then we evaluate them on a case-by-case basis.

Q How has the feedback been, considering Oracle chose to base its enterprise Linux distribution on RHEL?

Customers look for a single-solution support vendor, and if they get everything from one vendor, it is magic.

The enterprise customers want one version of Linux so that there is hardware and software compatibility. Our approach is to offer enterprise customers the entire stack and not just one component of that stack. At Oracle, what we do is called validate configurations, which includes storage, servers, database applications and, obviously, operation system versions.

When customers come to us and ask for an ERP solution, we have a solution for them. But what kind of an answer does Red Hat have for the same customer? Typically, "I don't know, but I can tell you this pack of Linux is great for this piece of hardware."